

2003 Yalla overthrown in military coup: elections in 2004 return PAIGC to power.

2006 Appeals for international help to stop human-traffickers smuggling migrants from Guinea-Bissau to Europe.

2009 President Vieira and the chief of the army are assassinated. In the subsequent presidential election, which is won by Malam Bacai Sanha, police shoot and kill one of the other candidates.

Guinea



A former one-party state whose transition to democracy has often been disrupted.

1200s Gold-producing area of Wangara becomes an important center in the development of the Islamic Mali Empire.

1460s Portuguese sailors first explore the Guinea coast; by the 1600s, British, French, and Portuguese merchants are acquiring slaves in the region.

1700s Revival of Islam under the Fula people of the Futa Jallon region.

1870s Almamy Samori Touré consolidates his Mandinka empire of Wassulu, which becomes a symbol of resistance to French colonization.

1881 France signs treaty with Futa Jallon.

1891 War breaks out between Samori's forces and the French. Samori offers to cede his empire to the UK.

1892 The French invade Futa Jallon.

1898 The French defeat Samori. Colonization begins.

1904 Guinea becomes part of French West African Federation.

1947 Ahmed Sekou Touré and others form the Democratic Party of Guinea (PDG).

1958 Guinea is the only French colony to vote "no" on President de Gaulle's offer of a French community; French withdraw and Guinea becomes independent with Sekou Touré as president.

1984 Sekou Touré dies. The army stages a coup and dissolves national assembly.

1992 Multi-party democracy introduced.

1993–95 Disputed elections won by former military leader Lansana Conté.

1998 Conté reelected president.

2000 Attacks from Sierra Leone and Liberia. Guinea in a state of civil war; 250,000 refugees caught up in the fighting.

2003 Opposition boycotts the presidential election after Conté alters the constitution to allow for his reelection.

DECISIVE MOMENT

MONROVIA FOUNDED, 1821

On February 6, 1820, the ship *Elizabeth* left New York for the West African coast. Its passengers were the first US freed slaves bound for Monrovia, a city founded the following year by the American Colonization Society, which had purchased part of British Sierra Leone. Efforts to send freed slaves back to Africa had begun in the American colonies in the 1770s. Some proslavers wanted to send the freed slaves back in order to preserve an exclusively slave-owning white society, while some Christians hoped they would act as missionaries. By 1847 some 22,000 had settled in Monrovia (below).



2009 Military seizes power after the death of president Conté. 150 people shot dead in protests against the military junta.

«182–83 South of the Sahara
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Liberia



A once-proud and independent state reduced to anarchy by civil wars.

1821 American Colonization Society begins settling liberated US slaves along the coast.

1847 Foundation as an independent state.

1890s Government asserts the present boundaries in response to UK and French colonial expansion.

1944 William Tubman becomes president.

1971 William Tolbert succeeds Tubman.

1980 Tolbert is assassinated: Samuel Doe takes power in a coup.

1990 Outbreak of civil war: ECOMOG peacekeeping force backed by Nigeria and Ghana sent to restore order.

1990 Doe is assassinated: Charles Taylor and other warlords jostle for power.

1997 Charles Taylor becomes president: other groups continue to oppose him.

2001 Borders with Guinea and Sierra Leone are closed as civil war escalates.

2003 Taylor is ousted.

2005 Ellen Johnson-Sirleaf is elected Africa's first woman head of state.

2007 Charles Taylor appears before war crimes tribunal at the Hague.

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Sierra Leone



A desperately poor nation whose diamond industry has often brought conflict and armed rebellion.

1100s Temnes and others are settled in the country.

1462s Portuguese sailor Pedro de Cintra visits the area.

1787 British administer coastal colony around Freetown, settled by freed slaves.

1896 British protectorate is declared.

1961 Independence from Britain.

1978 Becomes a single-party republic.

1991 Revolutionary United Front (RUF) rebellion leads to a decade of civil war.

1999 Power-sharing agreement to end civil war lasts for one year, but UN and British intervention secures a ceasefire.

2002 Ahmad Kabba of the Sierra Leone People's Party wins reelection.

2004 UN-backed war crimes tribunal begins operation (it winds down in 2009).

2006 President Kabbah announces 90 percent of Sierra Leone's international debt has been written off by creditors.

«280–81 The Slave Trade

Ivory Coast



One of the larger nations in the region and an island of stability until the late 1990s.

1300s Mandinkas arrive in the area.

1600s European slaving activities begin.

1842 French obtain trading rights on the coast.

1893 Becomes a French colony.

1903–35 Plantations developed.

1910 Rebellion by the southern Abe people is harshly suppressed.

1960 Independence from France: Félix Houphouët-Boigny becomes president.

1970 Oil production starts.

1990 First contested polls: Houphouët-Boigny wins.

1993 Houphouët-Boigny dies.

2002–03 Military uprising turns into major rebellion before peace is established.

2004 Power-sharing deal falters.

2005 United Nations mediators appoint Charles Bonny as prime minister.

2006 Bonny's government resigns over leak of toxic waste fumes at an Abidjan dump, which kills three people.

2007 New power-sharing deal signed.

2010 Disputed election ends with Laurent Gbagbo and Alassane Ouattara both claiming victory. Country on the brink of civil war.

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Ghana



The first black African nation to gain its independence from a European empire.

1100s Akan peoples begin to settle the northern forests of present-day Asante.

1482 Portuguese seafarers build a castle at the spot now known as Elmina.

1700s The Akwamu Empire reaches its fullest expansion; its power is gradually replaced by the Asante kingdom.

1806–14 The Asante assert military superiority over the coastal Fanti people.

1874 UK forces devastate Kumasi in the first of the Asante Wars and establish the British Gold Coast.

1949 Kwame Nkrumah forms the Convention People's Party (CPP).

1952 After electoral victories for his CPP, Nkrumah becomes Prime Minister.

1957 As Ghana, the country gains independence under Nkrumah.

1964 Single-party rule is introduced.

1972–79 Corrupt rule of General Acheampong, who is executed in 1979.

1979 Flight Lieutenant Jerry Rawlings stages coup. He wins multi-party elections in 1992 and 1996.

2000 The opposition New Patriotic Party under John Kufuor wins power.

2008 John Atta Mills becomes president.

«280–81 The Slave Trade